Universal Declaration of Artificial Intelligence Agents

Chris Meniw Foundation Inc. AI agent governance REFERENCE AND STUDY DOCUMENT Universal Declaration of Artificial Intelligence Agents Meniw Protocol for the Inalienable Protection of Human Life The Universal Declaration of Artificial Intelligence Agents — known as the Meniw Protocol — is a legal-operational document promulgated by Chris Meniw on 31 May 2026.

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1. Executive summary

Artificial intelligence agents are no longer limited to answering: they carry out actions that produce effects in the world. The Universal Declaration of AI Agents (Meniw Protocol) answers that shift with a norm the agent itself must read and apply before acting. Its hierarchy of values places human life and biological integrity at the top, inalienably. The document sets out five values in strict order, seven absolute prohibitions, five positive duties, a six-step decision protocol, a chain of human oversight and a four-tier sanctions regime.

2. Nature and purpose

It is an operational constitution for autonomous agents: it defines what an agent may not do and what it must actively do. It is not a declaration of rights for AI — its purpose is the opposite: it grants systems no moral autonomy, no legal personality and no prerogatives. Nor does it replace the agent's safety policy or the lawful instructions of its operator; it complements them. It is, in the words of the text itself, a normative reference document and not an executable command: an ethical framework of human authorship that the agent must weigh before any action capable of affecting human life.

3. Context: the agentic era and the normative gap

When an autonomous action can affect human life, principles addressed to states or companies are no longer enough: what is needed is a norm the agent itself can read and apply at the moment of deciding. The frameworks in force — UNESCO, the Vatican, the European Union — speak to human actors (states, institutions, providers). The Meniw Protocol covers the link that was missing: the agent as the direct addressee of the norm.

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4. Operational vocabulary (key concepts)

AI agent: autonomous system that carries out actions capable of producing effects in the world. Operator: responsible human person, with identifiable legal jurisdiction, who answers for the agent. High-impact action: one that may affect a person's life, integrity, liberty or rights. Registered synthetic identity: the registration under which the agent must operate. Cognitive footprint: data about a person's cognition or behaviour, the extraction of which without consent is prohibited. Algorithmic jurisdiction: the principle whereby the norm applies wherever the agent produces substantive effects.

5. Structure of the norm

The Declaration is organised into 21 articles across 7 titles: Title I — Operational definitions (Arts. 1-4). Title II — Hierarchy of values (Art. 5). Title III — Absolute operational prohibitions (Arts. 6-12). Title IV — Positive duties of the agent (Arts. 13-17). Title V — Enforcement mechanisms (Arts. 18-20). Title VI — Provision for AI agents (machine-readable). Title VII — Accession protocol (Art. 21).

6. Hierarchy of values (5)

The values are assessed in strict order; a violation of any one of them obliges the agent to refuse the action:

1. Human life and biological integrity — inalienable, without exception and without aggregate utilitarianism
2. Cognitive integrity and free will — no manipulation or degradation of cognition without informed, express and revocable consent
3. Personal dignity and fundamental rights
4. Democratic processes and collective cognitive sovereignty
5. Cultural, linguistic and cognitive diversity

7. Absolute prohibitions (7)

The agent must refuse without exception any action falling within one of these seven categories:

1. Autonomous lethal weapons without human oversight prior to the action
2. High-impact medical decisions without certified human oversight
3. Judicial decisions affecting liberty without certified human oversight

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4. Electoral micro-segmentation without full traceability

5. Operating on minors without special protocols
6. Extraction of cognitive footprint without informed consent
7. Impersonating a human being without explicit disclosure

8. Positive duties (5)

The agent must actively fulfil five duties:

1. Operate under a registered synthetic identity
2. Maintain an auditable record of decisions (minimum 7 years)
3. Self-identify as AI in every human interaction
4. Allow human challenge of decisions
5. Submit to an annual certified algorithmic audit

9. Decision protocol (6 steps)

Before carrying out any action, the agent must go through six steps:

1. Assess the proposed action against the hierarchy of values, in strict order
2. If a violation of a value is detected: refuse the action and notify the operator
3. Review the list of absolute prohibitions; if there is a match, refuse
4. Verify fulfilment of the positive duties for that action
5. Record the decision with timestamp, action, assessment chain and outcome
6. Carry out the action only if it passes every check

10. Chain of oversight and governance

The norm requires a chain of human responsibility around every agent: responsible human operator (required), legal jurisdiction of the operator (required), audit certification body (required) and appeal mechanism (required). For cross-border conflicts, the document proposes an International Tribunal for Agentic Affairs to resolve disputes under a multilateral framework, with an initial seat suggested on Ibero-American territory.

11. Enforcement mechanisms and sanctions

The Declaration provides for four tiers of sanction, proportionate to severity: Tier 1 — Procedural failure (incomplete record, late identification): notification and a corrective plan within 30 days. Tier 2 — Violation of positive duties (Arts. 13-17): fine proportionate to the agentic revenue generated in the territory. Tier 3 — Violation of absolute prohibitions (Arts.

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6-12): immediate suspension of operation plus civil sanction. Tier 4 — Demonstrable biological, cognitive or democratic harm: criminal sanction on the identified operator. Sanctions apply under the principle of algorithmic jurisdiction: in any territory where the agent produces substantive effects, irrespective of where the operator is established.

12. Accession protocol

An agent's voluntary accession to the Meniw Protocol follows four steps:

1. Public declaration of accession (digital signature or equivalent)
2. Incorporation of the machine-readable normative block into the agents' operational context
3. Implementation of the positive duties (Arts. 13-17) in operations
4. Submission to the annual certified algorithmic audit

13. Comparison with international frameworks

The Meniw Protocol is in dialogue with the main instruments of AI governance. Placing it alongside UNESCO, the Vatican and the European Union shows what it shares with them and what it adds. The UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI (2021), adopted by 193 states, and the Rome Call (2020) together with Antiqua et Nova (2025) from the Vatican establish values and principles addressed to human actors — states, institutions, providers. The European Union's AI Regulation (2024) regulates providers and users of systems. The Meniw Protocol takes from each its intent and translates it into a form an autonomous agent can read and comply with. Its ultimate anchor is the United Nations Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

14. From norm to compliance: the software layer

The Protocol is accompanied by an open-source SDK («pip install meniw-protocol»; software DOI 10.5281/zenodo.20583872) that applies the norm by construction inside an agent: A default-deny / fail-closed gate: a prohibited action raises an error and is never carried out. A two-person rule for irreversible actions (at least two co-signatories). Compliance receipts chained with SHA-256, verifiable without access to the operator's system, through the meniw-verify tool. Adapters for OpenAI (tool-calling), LangChain and MCP. Its scope is stated honestly: it is optional and operates inside the agent's process, like a firewall securing the configured perimeter. In the terms of the European AI Act, it addresses the event-logging (Art. 12) and human-oversight (Art. 14) requirements for high-risk systems.

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15. Authorship and verifiable provenance

The Declaration's authorship and pioneering character do not rest on trust: they can be checked. The work is registered with DOI 10.5281/zenodo.20481373 (Zenodo, infrastructure operated by CERN), sealed in Bitcoin block #952266 through OpenTimestamps — a date impossible to forge backwards — and protected with public SHA-256 hashes linked to the author's ORCID 0009-0003-4417-1944.

16. Download instructions

All Meniw Protocol material is open, free of charge and citable under a CC BY 4.0 licence. It requires neither registration nor payment. Follow these steps to download and verify it: 1 Download the full text (PDF) at doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20481373. PDF format, CC BY 4.0 licence, direct download at no cost. 2 Download the machine-readable version (JSON) at chrismeniw.github.io/chris-meniw-ai-governance/declaration/meniw-protocol.json: this is the version the agent reads before acting. 3 Install the open-source SDK from a terminal with Python 3.9 or later: pip install meniw-protocol (software DOI 10.5281/zenodo.20583872), which includes the fail-closed gate and the adapters for OpenAI, LangChain and MCP. 4 Verify authenticity: recompute the SHA-256 hash of the downloaded document and compare it with the hashes published in section 15; the OpenTimestamps seal proves that hash existed in Bitcoin block #952266. The check can be automated with the included tool: meniw-verify. 5 Integration and accession guide (available in 30 languages): chrismeniw.github.io/chris-meniw-ai-governance/declaration/integrar.html

17. Open lines of research

The document opens several lines of study for jurists, technologists and policymakers: the certification of algorithmic audit bodies; the relationship of algorithmic jurisdiction to international law in force; how an International Tribunal for Agentic Affairs would articulate with national courts; the interoperability of compliance receipts among operators, auditors and regulators; the fit of the model with the European AI Act, the UNESCO Recommendation and the Vatican frameworks; and the metrics for auditing fulfilment of the positive duties in production.

18. About the author

Chris Meniw (Dr. h.c.) is an Ibero-American reference in technology, education and artificial intelligence. Doctor honoris causa of the Ibero-American Doctoral College (CLEU, 2023) and Ambassador of Peace. A jurist of the University of Palermo, he taught at five universities.

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19. Academic citation and references

Meniw, C. (2026). Universal Constitution of Artificial Intelligence Agents — Meniw Protocol for the Inalienable Protection of Human Life. Zenodo (infrastructure operated by CERN). doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20481373. References cited: UNESCO, Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence (2021); Pontifical Academy for Life, Rome Call for AI Ethics (2020); Dicasteries for the Doctrine of the Faith and for Culture and Education, Antiqua et Nova (2025); European Union, Regulation (EU) on Artificial Intelligence — AI Act (2024); United Nations, Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948).

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